

Where is Paradise?

Many commentators, tradition, and even good preachers will tell you that “*paradise*” is the same as “*Abraham’s bosom*”. But, what is that conclusion based on and how did they come to that conclusion? Let’s have a look at what the Bible says.

Abraham’s bosom is mentioned only twice in the entire Bible and they both appear in [Luke 16](#).

[Luke 16:19-31](#)

19 There was a certain rich man, which was clothed in purple and fine linen, and fared sumptuously every day:
20 And there was a certain beggar named Lazarus, which was laid at his gate, full of sores,
21 And desiring to be fed with the crumbs which fell from the rich man's table: moreover the dogs came and licked his sores.
22 And it came to pass, that the beggar died, and was carried by the angels into **Abraham's bosom**: the rich man also died, and was buried;
23 And in **hell** he lift up his eyes, being in torments, and seeth **Abraham** afar off, and **Lazarus in his bosom**.
24 And he cried and said, Father Abraham, have mercy on me, and send Lazarus, that he may dip the tip of his finger in water, and cool my tongue; for I am tormented in this flame.
25 But Abraham said, Son, remember that thou in thy lifetime receivedst thy good things, and likewise Lazarus evil things: but now he is **comforted**, and thou art **tormented**.
26 And beside all this, between us and you there is a great gulf fixed: so that they which would pass from hence to you cannot; neither can they pass to us, that would come from thence.
27 Then he said, I pray thee therefore, father, that thou wouldest send him to my father's house:
28 For I have five brethren; that he may testify unto them, lest they also come into this place of torment.
29 Abraham saith unto him, They have Moses and the prophets; let them hear them.
30 And he said, Nay, father Abraham: but if one went unto them from the dead, they will repent.
31 And he said unto him, If they hear not Moses and the prophets, neither will they be persuaded, though one rose from the dead.

The only definition we’re given from the context is that “Abraham’s bosom” is also the same place as the “comfort side of hell” (which means that Abraham’s bosom **is in** hell). Keep that in mind as we look at every usage of the word “paradise” below.

Likewise, the “torment side of hell” is the place that most people colloquially refer to as “hell” without realizing that before Jesus’ death, burial, and resurrection **everyone** went to “hell” (AKA “the grave” [Gen 37:35](#), “the pit” [Num 16:30](#), and “hell” [Deu 32:22](#) in the OT).

Summary:

- There’s **no** direct connection
 - [Genesis 1:8](#) “firmament” = “heaven”
 - [John 11:11-14](#) (sometimes) “sleep” = “dead”
- There’s **no** parallelism
 - [Judges 18:17-20](#) “graven” = “carved”
 - [1 Samuel 20:24-27](#) “new moon” = “first day of the month”

The word “paradise” appears three times in the entire Bible (Luke 23:43, 2 Corinthians 12:4, Revelation 2:7).

Luke 23:43

And Jesus said unto him, **Verily I say unto thee, To day^{G4594} shalt thou be with me in paradise^{G3857}.**

- To the penitent thief on the cross beside Jesus it was promised that that day he would be in “paradise” with Jesus.
 - When He said “to day” He very specifically meant “this day” (the evening and the morning): not a day as in the unspecified sense such as in Joel 2:31, the continual (daily) sense such as in Exodus 13:21, the monthly (new moon) sense as in Genesis 8:5, or the dawn (first light in the morning) as in Genesis 32:24.
- Since Jesus descended into the lower parts of the earth where all the dead previously went, it makes sense that some might equate the comfort side of hell to paradise **if you isolate this verse by itself**. However, when considering the implications of that in light of all of scripture, cracks begin to form immediately. For example: Those that were in the comfort side of hell were *brought to* God. The ransom was paid and they were bought *back*. These concepts from scripture necessitate a separation from God. If the comfort side of hell was the same place as paradise then God’s abode would have already been there and there would be no need to *bring them* to God.

2 Corinthians 12:1-4

¹ It is not expedient for me doubtless to glory. I will come to visions and revelations of the Lord.

² I knew a man in Christ above fourteen years ago, (whether in the body, I cannot tell; or whether out of the body, I cannot tell: God knoweth;) such an one **caught up to the third heaven**.

³ And I knew such a man, (whether in the body, or out of the body, I cannot tell: God knoweth;)

⁴ How that he was **caught up into paradise^{G3857}**, and heard unspeakable words, which it is not lawful for a man to utter.

⁵ **Of such an one will I glory:** yet of myself I will not glory, but in mine infirmities.

- The same place is referred to by two different names: “paradise” and “the third heaven”.
- If paradise was the comfort side of hell we would expect to see hell^{G86} (or an equivalent word or phrase) here instead of “the third heaven”. Instead, we see a phrase that is not only new but also entirely unique (which also means that there is **one** definition for “the third heaven” and that is “paradise”).
- We are only to glory in the Lord (Jeremiah 9:23,24, 1 Corinthians 1:31, 3:21, 2 Corinthians 10:17) so then v5a refers to the Lord. Wherever this third heaven/paradise is, the Lord is also there (Mark 16:19, Hebrews 10:12).

Revelation 2:7

He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches; To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the paradise^{G3857} of God.

Revelation 22:1-2

¹ And he shewed me a pure river of water of life, clear as crystal, proceeding out of the **throne of God and of the Lamb**.

² In the midst of the street of it, and on either side of the river, *was there* the **tree of life**, which bare twelve *manner of* fruits, *and* yielded her fruit every month: and the leaves of the tree *were* for the healing of the nations.

- The tree of life is in the middle of the garden planted by the LORD God in Genesis 2:8,9. It is in the middle of the **paradise** of God in Revelation 2:7. After the new heaven and new earth is created (Revelation 21) the tree of life is in the middle of and on both sides of the pure river of water of life. None of these appear to be anywhere near the comfort side of hell.

Just like we saw above, none of these verses tell us that “Abraham’s bosom” is also “paradise” and they all appear to be talking about one single place. If Abraham’s bosom and paradise were the same place then one of the usages of “paradise” above would necessarily have a different definition than the other two **with no scriptural evidence to back that up**.

So if the idea of “paradise” being the same place as “Abraham’s bosom” did not originate from the Bible, as the evidence clearly suggests, that begs the question: where did it come from?

1. **The Jewish Roots** (2nd Century B.C. – 1st Century A.D.)

- In **Jewish** thought, being in the “bosom” of a patriarch was a metaphor for the highest place of honor at a banquet ([John 13:23](#)). Non-canonical works like “4 Maccabees” (13:17) and the “Apocalypse of Zephaniah” describe the righteous being received by Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. During that same time period “Abraham’s bosom” and “paradise” began to be used to describe the “righteous compartment” of Sheol **as a cultural idiom** ([Mark 7:7](#)).

2. **Early Church Fathers** (2nd – 3rd Century A.D.)

- The formal propagation of this idea among Christians began with the early theologians who sought to map out the afterlife.
 - **Tertullian** (c. 160–225 A.D.): In his work *Against Marcion* (Book IV, chapter 34), Tertullian explicitly calls Abraham’s bosom a “temporary receptacle” for the faithful. He distinguished it from the highest Heaven but he helped bridge the gap by describing it as a place of “refreshment.”
 - Tertullian argued that no human—not even the righteous—enters the highest heaven or the presence of God **until after** the resurrection and the **final judgment***.
 - **Hippolytus** of Rome (c. 170–235 A.D.): In his *Against Plato, on the Cause of the Universe*, he describes Hades as having a “locality” for the righteous called Abraham’s Bosom, which he characterizes as a place of light and “perpetual flowers”—language almost identical to the classical Greek and Jewish descriptions of Paradise.

3. **The Roman Catholic Consolidation** (Middle Ages)

- “Limbo of the Fathers” (*Limbus Patrum*)
 - **The Roman Catholic Church** taught that the righteous who died before Christ (the Old Testament saints) were held in a place of rest.
 - They officially identified this “Limbo” as being Abraham’s Bosom. To make the theology consistent, they taught that when Jesus told the thief on the cross, “To day shalt thou be with me in paradise,” **He was referring to this same “Limbo” or “Bosom” where He would descend after death****.
 - By the time of the Renaissance, the two terms were treated as synonyms in nearly all ecclesiastical art and commentary.

4. **The Propagation into Modern Theology**

- Post-Reformation, many commentators continued to carry this tradition forward:
 - **Maldonatus** (1583): A **Jesuit** commentator whose work heavily influenced later scholars, **he argued** that “Abraham’s Bosom” was simply a Jewish metaphor for “Paradise.”
 - **Modern Study Bibles**: Many modern notes in the margins of non-KJV Bibles (like the Scofield or various study editions) continue this lineage by stating as a “fact” that [Luke 16](#) describes “Paradise,” **despite the word never appearing in that chapter**.

* The Bible teaches us that after Jesus’ death, burial, and resurrection, that the “comfort side of hell” was emptied and that thereafter all the saints go directly to the presence of God without waiting in hell ([Matthew 27:52,53](#), [Ephesians 4:8](#), [Philippians 1:23](#), [2 Corinthians 5:8](#), [Revelation 1:18](#)).

** This assertion can not be proven with the Bible.